

Supporting Information

How Can You Think That? Deliberation and the Learning of Opposing Arguments

Gaurav Sood

Robert C. Luskin

James S. Fishkin

September 2026

This supplement reports the expanded descriptive and sensitivity results. All tables are generated by the analysis pipeline. Estimates use the primary coding unless a table states otherwise. Confidence intervals use CR2 standard errors with Satterthwaite degrees of freedom, clustering participants by discussion group and treating controls and the participant without a recorded group as singleton clusters.

1 Sample composition

Table 1: Composition of recruitment, participant, returnee, and control samples

Sample	<i>N</i>	Age	Women (%)	Catholic (%)	Degree (%)
T1 nonparticipant	444	40.0 (436)	69.1 (444)	72.6 (424)	18.8 (441)
T2 participant	124	40.7 (124)	75.8 (124)	65.8 (120)	19.5 (123)
T3 nonreturning participant	31	37.9 (31)	74.2 (31)	66.7 (30)	12.9 (31)
T3 returning participant	93	41.6 (93)	76.3 (93)	65.6 (90)	21.7 (92)
T3 control	150	40.0 (149)	72.7 (150)	73.9 (142)	18.7 (150)

Note: Cells contain a mean or percentage followed by the nonmissing denominator in parentheses. T1 nonparticipants completed the recruitment interview but did not attend the event. T3 nonreturning participants attended but did not complete the follow-up. T3 controls were recruited separately.

2 Policy-specific results

Table 2: Mean coded reasons and contrasts by policy and prompt

Policy	Prompt	T2 P	T3 P	T3 C	T2 P – T3 C	T3 P – T3 C	T3 – T2
All-ability schools	Pro-policy	1.71 (118)	1.19 (89)	1.00 (147)	0.71 [0.31, 1.12] (265)	0.19 [-0.11, 0.50] (236)	-0.56 [-1.03, -0.10] (85)
All-ability schools	Anti-policy	1.19 (119)	0.85 (92)	0.83 (145)	0.37 [-0.03, 0.77] (264)	0.02 [-0.24, 0.28] (237)	-0.43 [-0.91, 0.06] (89)
Balanced enrolment	Anti-policy	1.49 (123)	1.13 (92)	0.98 (146)	0.51 [0.22, 0.79] (269)	0.15 [-0.13, 0.43] (238)	-0.30 [-0.64, 0.04] (92)
Balanced enrolment	Pro-policy	1.88 (118)	1.60 (78)	1.26 (127)	0.62 [0.19, 1.05] (245)	0.34 [0.01, 0.67] (205)	-0.20 [-0.61, 0.21] (74)
Inclusive classrooms	Pro-policy	1.37 (124)	1.10 (92)	1.01 (147)	0.36 [0.01, 0.72] (271)	0.09 [-0.19, 0.37] (239)	-0.30 [-0.69, 0.08] (92)
Inclusive classrooms	Anti-policy	0.64 (121)	0.49 (93)	0.57 (150)	0.07 [-0.18, 0.32] (271)	-0.08 [-0.29, 0.13] (243)	-0.12 [-0.49, 0.25] (90)
Combined primary and post-primary schools	Pro-policy	0.92 (123)	1.02 (93)	0.72 (149)	0.19 [-0.08, 0.47] (272)	0.30 [0.04, 0.55] (242)	0.11 [-0.25, 0.47] (92)
Combined primary and post-primary schools	Anti-policy	0.79 (122)	0.92 (91)	0.81 (149)	-0.02 [-0.35, 0.31] (271)	0.12 [-0.15, 0.38] (240)	0.16 [-0.25, 0.56] (90)

Note: T2 P and T3 P denote participants at the end of the event and follow-up; T3 C denotes contemporaneous controls. The first two differences compare distinct samples. T3 minus T2 is a within-returnee change. Contrast cells contain an estimate and 95% confidence interval. Prompt labels refer to the policy direction, not to the respondent's own position. Parentheses contain the sample size for each mean or contrast.

3 Response-slot order

Table 3: Linear probability model for whether a response slot contains a valid reason

Term	Estimate	CR2 SE	CI low	CI high	Rows	Clusters
T3 participant	0.076	0.036	0.002	0.149	9656	170
Response-slot order	-0.130	0.006	-0.143	-0.118	9656	170
Participant $\times$ response-slot order	-0.024	0.010	-0.044	-0.005	9656	170

Note: The T3 slot-level model includes policy and prompt-side fixed effects. Response slot order runs from zero for the first offered slot to four for the fifth. The participant coefficient is therefore the participant–control difference at the first slot; the interaction shows how that difference changes across later slots. The model describes response production, not a causal effect of participation.

4 Coding sensitivity

Table 4: Sensitivity of the total-repertoire T3 comparison to coding choices

Outcome construction	T3 difference [95% CI]	N	Clusters
Inclusive low-credit coding	1.00 [-0.83, 2.84]	185	134
Count every coded mention	1.15 [-0.65, 2.96]	185	134
Coder 1	1.28 [-0.23, 2.78]	243	170
Coder 2	1.08 [-0.38, 2.55]	243	170

Note: Estimates are participant minus control. Inclusive coding retains question-specific low-credit answers. The mention count credits each distinct code rather than each occupied response slot. Coder-specific outcomes do not require adjudication and therefore retain more respondents.

Table 5: Sensitivity of directional balance to coding choices

Construction	T3 difference [95% CI]	N (T3)	Paired change [95% CI]	N (paired)
Inclusive coding: b	0.03 [-0.10, 0.15]	177	-0.20 [-0.34, -0.06]	51
Inclusive coding: $ b $	-0.04 [-0.13, 0.05]	177	-0.17 [-0.27, -0.07]	51
Coder 1: b	-0.01 [-0.12, 0.10]	221	-0.14 [-0.29, 0.01]	78
Coder 1: $ b $	-0.04 [-0.14, 0.05]	221	-0.10 [-0.21, 0.02]	78
Coder 2: b	0.03 [-0.09, 0.14]	221	-0.12 [-0.25, 0.01]	78
Coder 2: $ b $	-0.02 [-0.11, 0.08]	221	-0.07 [-0.16, 0.02]	78

Note: Directional balance is $b = (s - o)/(s + o)$ and absolute imbalance is $|b|$. Balance is undefined for a zero repertoire. T3 differences are participant minus control; paired changes are T3 minus T2. Inclusive coding retains low-credit responses but still requires completed adjudication. Coder-specific outcomes retain unadjudicated cases.

5 Religious-community descriptions

Table 6: T3 total repertoires by religious community

Community	Control mean	<i>N</i> control	Participant mean	<i>N</i> participant	Difference [95% CI]	<i>N</i> difference
Catholic	7.33	85	7.77	43	0.44 [-1.97, 2.84]	128
Protestant	4.82	22	7.88	26	3.07 [0.81, 5.32]	48

Note: Differences are participant minus control. Respondents outside the two largest religious communities and respondents with missing affiliation are omitted. These subgroup estimates are descriptive, were not selected as separate confirmatory tests, and should not be read as evidence of effect heterogeneity.

6 Coding rules and reproducibility

The substantive categories follow the original codebook. Codes for “other” remain valid; codes for nonsensical, missing, and vague responses do not. For three prompts, code three attributes the opposing position to prejudice or ignorance rather than stating a policy reason. The primary measure excludes that code; the inclusive sensitivity retains it.

Coder labels are normalized to sorted integer sets before agreement is evaluated. If both coders provide the same set, that set is final. If they differ and the adjudicator provides a set, the adjudicated set is final. If they differ without adjudication, the primary respondent- wave outcome is unresolved. Coder-specific sensitivities preserve those observations.

The numbered R scripts create the analysis data, one bundled results object, headline CSV files, tables, figures, and manuscript macros. Running `make check` lints the code, rebuilds every output, runs the validation tests, and compiles the article and this supplement.